Ransomware Incident Reconstruction

Atlas Continental Corporation - Full Kill Chain Analysis

Source log file: ../pcap/atlas_continental_ransomware_incident.pcap
Report generated: 2026-08-22 10:54:34
Generated by: Log Analysis Toolkit

CRITICAL: Ransomware (The Gentlemen) impacted an estimated 5,000 endpoints across 6 offices, 600 TB exfiltrated, active backdoor persistence detected after ransom payment

Executive Summary

Threat actor	The Gentlemen
Initial access	Spear-phishing email with double-extension executable attachment
Declared scope (IR/EDR telemetry)	5,000 endpoints across Chicago (HQ), Dubai, New York, Auckland, Berlin, Johannesburg
Sample captured in this pcap	44 representative hosts across 6 offices
Data exfiltrated (declared)	600 TB
Ransom demanded	$5,000,000 USD in Bitcoin
Ransom negotiated / paid	$1,250,000 USD in Bitcoin
Negotiation duration	3.3 days, 24 messages
Decryption key delivered	Yes
Persistent backdoor after resolution	CRITICAL: 12 beacons from 2 host(s)

Phase 1: Initial Access - Spear-Phishing Email

The intrusion began with a spear-phishing email impersonating the HR payroll department, sent from a typosquat domain, using a subject line designed to prompt urgent action from the recipient.

Sender (spoofed)	HR Payroll Services <hr.payroll@atlas-hr-payroll-secure.net>
Subject	Confidential: 2026 Salary Increase Notification - Action Required by EOD
Malicious attachment	SalaryIncrease.pdf.exe
Recipient	d.kowalski@atlascontinental.com (Senior Systems Administrator)

The attachment used a double file extension (a PDF icon with a hidden .exe extension) to disguise an executable as a harmless salary document, a classic social engineering technique that relies on Windows hiding known file extensions by default.

Phase 2: Malware Detonation and Command-and-Control

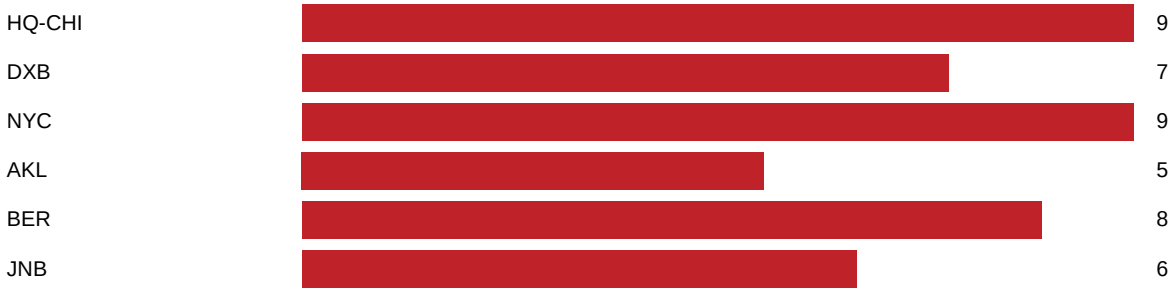
Opening the attachment triggered a dropper that resolved a command-and-control domain and downloaded a second-stage payload before establishing a recurring beacon channel.

C2 domain queried	DNS queries observed
cdn-updates-secure.xyz	50

Phase 3: Lateral Spread Across the Global Estate

Beacon check-ins were observed from 44 representative hosts across 6 office networks over roughly 30 hours, consistent with automated lateral movement following business hours in each time zone. The organization's asset inventory and EDR platform corroborate a much larger blast radius of approximately 5,000 endpoints; this packet capture holds a representative sample rather than full-packet data for every host.

Infected hosts observed per office (sample)



Phase 4: Data Exfiltration

Prior to encryption, data was staged and exfiltrated to 45.147.230.55. The declared total across the full estate is 600 TB; the manifest headers captured in this sample identify the categories involved:

Category	Archive filename	Declared size
Financial_Records	Q1-Q4_2026_Consolidated_Financials.xlsx.tar.gz	18.4 TB
Customer_Data	Global_Customer_Database_Export.sql.tar.gz	142.7 TB
Source_Code	Atlas_Core_Platform_Source_Repositories.tar.gz	9.2 TB
Employee_PII	Global_HR_Employee_Records_AllOffices.csv.tar.gz	3.1 TB
Engineering_Archives	Product_Design_And_Engineering_Archives.tar.gz	426.6 TB

Phase 5: Mass Encryption and Ransom Note

A ransom note titled README_DECRYPT_THE_GENTLEMEN.txt was dropped on file shares in all 6 office networks captured. Full text recovered from the capture:

SMB2 WRITE README_DECRYPT_THE_GENTLEMEN.txt
==========
  YOUR NETWORK HAS BEEN ENCRYPTED BY THE GENTLEMEN
==========
All servers, workstations, and backups across your organization
(5,000+ endpoints, 6 global offices) have been encrypted.
We have also copied 600 TB of your confidential data, including
financial records, source code, employee records, and customer data.

Ransom demand: 5,000,000 USD in Bitcoin
Wallet: bc1qthegentlemen7x9k2m4n8p1q5r3s6t8u9v0w2x4y6z

You have 5 DAYS. If payment is not received, all stolen data will

be published on our leak site and the decryption key destroyed.

To begin negotiation, connect to our support portal via Tor:
thegentlemenxyz7q9k2m4n8p1q5r3s6t.onion (relay observed: 91.219.237.44:9050)
==========

Phase 6: Dark Web Negotiation (Full Transcript)

The IR team negotiated with The Gentlemen over a Tor bridge relay across 3.3 days and 24 messages. The ransom was negotiated down from $5,000,000 to $1,250,000.

[2026-09-03 19:14] IR Team: Hello. This is Atlas Continental IR team. We received your note.

[2026-09-03 19:18] The Gentlemen: Welcome. We are The Gentlemen. We have your data and your systems. Do you wish to resolve this professionally?

[2026-09-03 19:23] IR Team: Yes. Before anything else we need proof you can actually decrypt our files.

[2026-09-03 19:26] The Gentlemen: Understood. Send us one encrypted file under 5MB and we will decrypt it free of charge as proof.

[2026-09-03 20:44] IR Team: Sending test file: HR_template_locked.gentlemen_locked

[2026-09-03 21:19] The Gentlemen: Decrypted and returned. As you can see, our tooling works perfectly. The rest is simple math: pay and this ends.

[2026-09-04 00:14] IR Team: 5,000,000 USD is not realistic for us. Our cyber insurance and board will not approve that figure.

[2026-09-04 00:54] The Gentlemen: Every company says this. We reviewed your public financials. You can afford it. The price is 5,000,000 USD.

[2026-09-04 18:14] IR Team: We can offer 750,000 USD, payable within 48 hours, to close this quickly for both sides.

[2026-09-04 18:59] The Gentlemen: That is insulting. We have your engineering archives, your customer database, and your payroll data. 4,500,000 USD, final courtesy discount.

[2026-09-04 23:24] IR Team: We understand the leverage you have. We can go to 1,000,000 USD. That is close to our real ceiling.

[2026-09-05 01:14] The Gentlemen: 1,000,000 USD is low, but we are, as our name suggests, gentlemen. We can accept 1,250,000 USD, final offer, no further discussion.

[2026-09-05 01:44] IR Team: Agreed, 1,250,000 USD. We need until day 5 to move funds through compliance and procure the BTC.

[2026-09-05 01:49] The Gentlemen: Acceptable. Remember: day 5, 23:59 UTC, or everything goes to our leak site. Wallet: bc1qthegentlemen7x9k2m4n8p1q5r3s6t8u9v0w2x4y6z

[2026-09-05 20:14] IR Team: Understood. We are proceeding with the BTC purchase now through our exchange desk.

[2026-09-05 20:34] The Gentlemen: Good. We are watching the wallet. Do not attempt to involve law enforcement trace teams, it will not help you and will slow decryption.

[2026-09-06 03:14] IR Team: No law enforcement is involved on our side of this channel. We are preparing the transaction now.

[2026-09-06 22:59] IR Team: Transaction broadcast. TXID: 3f9a7c2e1b6d4f8a0c5e2d9b7a4f1c6e8d3b0a7f5c2e9d6b4a1f8c3e0d7b5a2f

[2026-09-06 23:04] The Gentlemen: We see it in the mempool. Waiting for confirmations before releasing the key.

[2026-09-07 01:24] The Gentlemen: 6 confirmations received. Payment of 1,250,000 USD equivalent confirmed. Generating your universal decryption key now.

[2026-09-07 01:36] The Gentlemen: Decryption key: 8F3D1A9C7E2B5D6F0A4C8E1B3D7F9A2C5E8B1D4F7A0C3E6B9D2F5A8C1E4B7D0F

[2026-09-07 01:38] The Gentlemen: Run the decryptor tool from your original note link with this key against every share. All 6 offices use the same universal key.

[2026-09-07 03:14] IR Team: Received. Beginning decryption across all offices now. We consider this incident resolved on our end.

[2026-09-07 03:24] The Gentlemen: Pleasure doing business. As gentlemen, we destroy our copy of your data per our policy. Good luck.

Phase 7: Bitcoin Payment Confirmation

[CHAT] 6 confirmations received. Payment of 1,250,000 USD equivalent confirmed. Generating your universal decryption key now.

Phase 8: Decryption Key Handoff and Execution

Decryption key 8F3D1A9C7E2B5D6F0A4C8E1B3D7F9A2C5E8B1D4F7A0C3E6B9D2F5A8C1E4B7D0F

6 decryption executions were observed across office file servers, all reporting successful restoration.

Phase 9: CRITICAL - Persistent Backdoor After Resolution

12 beacon(s) from 2 host(s) to an undisclosed secondary host (95.216.201.77) continued AFTER the incident was declared resolved in chat.

Despite the attacker's claim to 'destroy our copy' of the data and the successful decryption of all systems, low-and-slow beacon traffic to a second, previously undisclosed command-and-control host continued for at least two more days. This is strong evidence of a retained backdoor and should be treated as an active, ongoing compromise regardless of ransom payment. Recommend full re-imaging of the affected hosts and estate-wide threat hunting for the same IOC.

Beaconing host
10.10.5.47
10.30.5.12